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POLITICS AIN'T FOR PATHANS

I'VE SEEN them all.

The CEOs, the chairmen, the presidents, the prime ministers, the pretenders. I've seen them all off too.

I once had a face-off with Ijaz Butt, an interestingly flawed former chairman of the PCB. I remember: the vultures were circling. I was close to being chucked out of the national cricket team again. And guess who popped up to offer help: Bilawal Bhutto Zardari.

The offer was interesting. In return for resolving the conflict with Butt, Bilawal's people said that I must accompany the young politician on rallies. Needless to say, I didn't take Bilawal's help. Let sleeping dogs lie on that story about the negotiations. But, on the political front, I think Bilawal has a long way to go. Unfortunately, the Pakistan Peoples Party perished with his mother, Benazir Bhutto sahiba. His father couldn't hack it. That's the honest truth as I see it.

When I met him in London, Bilawal was making a political pitch, asking me to join forces with him, even campaign with him. Personally, I met him only because I wanted to meet Benazir's son, hoping he would walk on the same path his late mother did. But I soon realized who was calling the shots in the PPP. Bilawal Bhutto Zardari was just a front, I realized. His hands are tied like a puppet's. He may eventually be leader of the party, but for now, his father is in charge. That still seems to be the case somewhat.

On the other side of the aisle: Mian Mohammad Nawaz Sharif, the former prime minister. Mian sahib too offered me a position in his party, the Pakistan Muslim League (Nawaz) (PML[N]). He made the proposal rather indirectly, in his particular style, by asking me to put a lion's sticker on my bat. The lion, of course, is the symbol of his wing of the Pakistan Muslim League. I laughed it off. There's no space for politics – not on the field.

Then, of course, is that famous moment when, before he became prime minister, or was even close to it, Imran Khan offered me to join his cause openly, during his months-long 2014 protest in Islamabad.